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AGENDA SETTING and VOTERS' MANIPULATION in PUBLIC ELECTIONS

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Case studies and possible counter-measures

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INTRODUCTION

AGENDA SETTING

It refers to the use of communication media to shape public opinion and encourages voters to base their voting decision on the issues presented in the campaign agenda.

- Attitude toward these issues that play to the candidate's strength

VOTING MANIPULATION

By the Gibbard-Satterthwaite theorem, **every reasonable non-dictatorial voting rule for 3 or more alternatives is susceptible to manipulation:** there exist elections where one or more voter can change the election outcome by casting a strategic vote rather than the sincere one

COMPROMISING

Insincerely expressing a **higher preference** for a compromise candidate to **increase its chance of victory, because they deem their sincere favourite unlikely to win**

voter	1st	2nd	3rd	4th
Alice	A	B	C	D
Bob	C	B	D	A
Charlie	C	B	D	A

Vote count : {A: 3, B: 6, C: 7, D: 2 }

voter	1st	2nd	3rd	4th
Alice	B	A	D	C
Bob	C	B	D	A
Charlie	C	B	D	A

Vote count : {A: 2, B: 7, C: 6, D: 2 }

BURYING

Insincerely expressing a **lower preference** for the strongest candidate to **decrease its chance** of **victory**

voter	1st	2nd	3rd	4th
Alice	D	B	C	A
Bob	B	C	A	D
Charlie	C	A	D	B

Vote count : {A: 3, B: 5, C: 5, D: 4 }

voter	1st	2nd	3rd	4th
Alice	D	B	A	C
Bob	B	C	A	D
Charlie	C	A	D	B

Vote count : {A: 4, B: 5, C: 4, D: 4 }

PUSH OVER

Insincerely expressing a **higher preference for a weak candidate** to **increase its chances to pass the first round**

voter	1st	2nd	3rd	4th
Alice	C	B	A	D
Bob	B	C	D	A
Charlie	C	B	A	D
David	B	C	A	D

Vote count : {A:3, B: 10, C: 10, D: 1 }

voter	1st	2nd	3rd	4th
Alice	D	C	A	B
Bob	B	C	D	A
Charlie	C	B	A	D
David	B	C	A	D

Vote count : {A:3, B: 8, C: 9, D: 4 }

BULLET VOTING

Insincerely expressing a **preference for only a single candidate** to **increase** that candidate's **chance of victory**

voter	1st	2nd	3rd	4th
Alice	D	B	C	A
Bob	B	A	D	C
Charlie	C	A	D	B

Vote count : {A:4, B: 5, C: 4, D: 5 }

voter	1st	2nd	3rd	4th
Alice	D			
Bob	B	A	D	C
Charlie	C	A	D	B

Vote count : {A:4, B: 3, C: 4, D: 5 }

FROM MASS MEDIA TO SOCIAL MEDIA

Electoral campaigns put disproportionate resources into ***competing in the first few stages****, which affect the reaction of voters' preference in later stages*

Mass media ability to reach the masses **decline due to increased selectivity and audience fragmentation**

↓

The **social media** allows to reach narrowly targeted voters and it increases incidental exposure to political information among those who might otherwise choose to avoid it

END-EFFECTS

Agenda-setting effects answer these **3 questions**

1) *What are the issues about?*

Media agenda are successful in transferring the salience of issues to news sources

2) *What are the dominant characteristics of these issues?*

Characteristics frequently mentioned by media agenda to define these issues

3) *What are the issues in our heads?*

The main approach is to mention elements simultaneously leading audience to associate these elements in their minds

UK

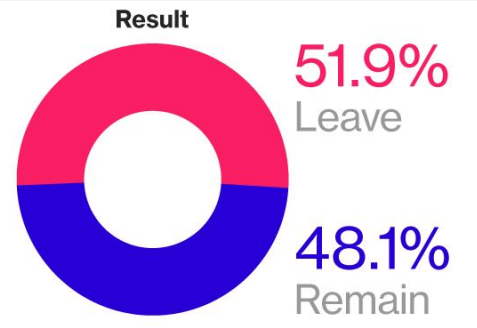
THE BREXIT CASE

23 June 2016 : **UK referendum on EU membership** (Art. 50 TEU)

The question facing voters was: '*Should the United Kingdom remain a member of the European Union or leave?*"

KEY ISSUES

- Based upon voting theory, the Brexit referendum question can be rejected as technically unsatisfactory and misleading
- A referendum result is democratically legitimate only if voters can make an informed decision



VOTING THEORY

Voting theory warns that allowing only two options can easily be a misleading representation of the real choice. When the situation is more complex, reducing the question to a binary one might suggest a political motivation

Representative democracy — Parliament — is **better than relying on referenda**, since the representatives can bargain about the complex choices involved

If voters could have chosen among **3 or more** distinct alternatives, it is Arrow's impossibility theorem that states that there is no ranked voting electoral system that can convert the ranked preferences of individuals into a community-wide. If they go back to only **2**, they may select the pair that fits their own interests

UK Electoral Commission was aware of this issue in voting theory, but they didn't protest and only checked that the question could be 'understood'

SCANDAL OF CAMBRIDGE ANALYTICA

NEWS > TECHNOLOGY

Cambridge Analytica helped 'cheat' Brexit vote and US election, claims whistleblower

The great British Brexit robbery: how our democracy was hijacked

Brexit: Foreign far-right Twitter users 'manipulated debate'

12 March 2019

Revealed: 50 million Facebook profiles harvested for Cambridge Analytica in major data breach

Brexit vote manipulated, says data whistleblower

SCANDAL OF CAMBRIDGE ANALYTICA

Chris Wylie, former director of research at Cambridge Analytica, said that they provided **analysis for the Vote Leave campaign ahead of the 2016 Brexit referendum**

The research breached the U.K.'s strict campaign financing laws

The **use of such data analytics by campaigns linked to leaving the EU** had a material effect in convincing many people how to vote

Significant number of **non-UK twitter accounts** (mostly US) involved in pro-Leave conversations and retweet activity

- Twitter accounts associated with the **far-right**

POST-TRUTH POLITICS

Artificial intelligence, algorithms and invisible money sources can overwhelm democratic rules. **Democracy struggles** in an era where lobbyists can weaponise fake news for the highest bidder. (*Ex. Electoral Commission do not have the resources to intervene and sanction.*)

Brexit is a key example of **post-truth politics**

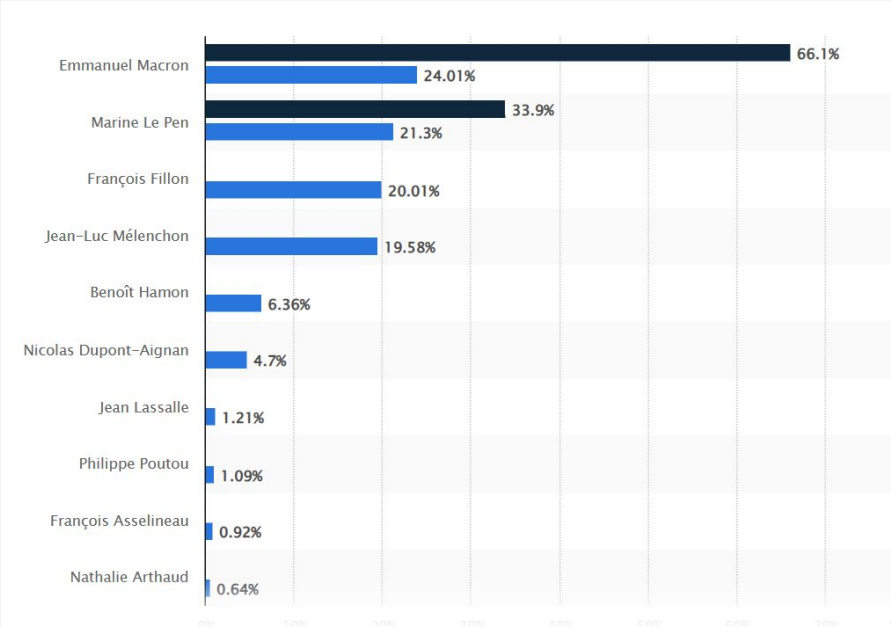
2 key factors ushered in this new form of politics into the UK:

1) **Technological changes** associated with social media
2) A **growing distrust in democratic institutions**, experts, and traditional media which leads, in turn, to a loss of trust in established expert knowledge

"The referendum was won by the side with the means to distribute the most plausible lies through media"

France

FRANCE PRESIDENTIAL ELECTIONS 2017



1° round : 23rd of April 2017

EMMANUEL MACRON VS MARINE LE PEN

2° round : 7th of May 2017

WINNER: EMMANUEL MACRON

Key issues

- **ALTERNATIVE FACTS**
- **CYBER ATTACK**

MARINE LE PEN ALTERNATIVE FACTS

ALTERNATIVE FACT = *False statement*

On average the use of alternative facts increases the political support of the politicians irrespective of fact checking.

The journal "**LE MONDE**" identified and fact-checked **19 alternative facts**, that Le Pen stated during her campaign

Migrants come to benefit from France's generous welfare system
"**5%** of the foreigners who come to France **HAVE A WORK CONTRACT.** This means that there are 95% of those coming to France who are taken care of by our nation"
According to the National Statistics Institute (INSEE) in 2015 **54.8%** of the immigrant population were in the **LABOUR FORCE** (working or looking for a job) versus 56.3% for the rest of the French population. The rate of **UNEMPLOYMENT** for the immigrant population is **18.1%** against 9.1%. There is 44.9% of immigrants that works.

EXPERIMENT on ALTERNATIVE FACTS

Study effectiveness of fact checking to undo the persuasive effect of alternative facts

All 2480 participants subsequently answered a survey on political preferences and factual knowledge

RESULTS :

1° FACT CHECKING DOES NOT CHANGE VOTERS' OPINION

2° FACT CHECKING HELPS TO ALIGN KNOWLEDGE

3° FACT CHECKING INCREASES SALIENCE OF THE TOPIC, and makes voters more worried about it

#MACRONLEAK

1°

DISINFORMATION CAMPAIGN

DISTORT PUBLIC IMAGE and REPUTATION

2°

HACKING STAFF COMPUTERS

STEAL DATA and INFORMATION

3°

LEAK 15 GB of DATA 5th MAY 2017

Hours before the "ELECTION SILENCE" to HINDER self DEFENCE

Promoted with X
½ million tweets in 24 hours

GUIDANCE AGAINST CYBERATTACKS

DIGITAL PLATFORM RESPONSIBILITY

Social media intervention vs misinformation plus newspapers responsibility

COMPARTMENTALIZE COMMUNICATION

By e-mail for trivial and logistics, encrypted apps for confidential, face to face for sensitive

STRUCTURAL REASONS

French elections are critical : two round of voting create an obstacle

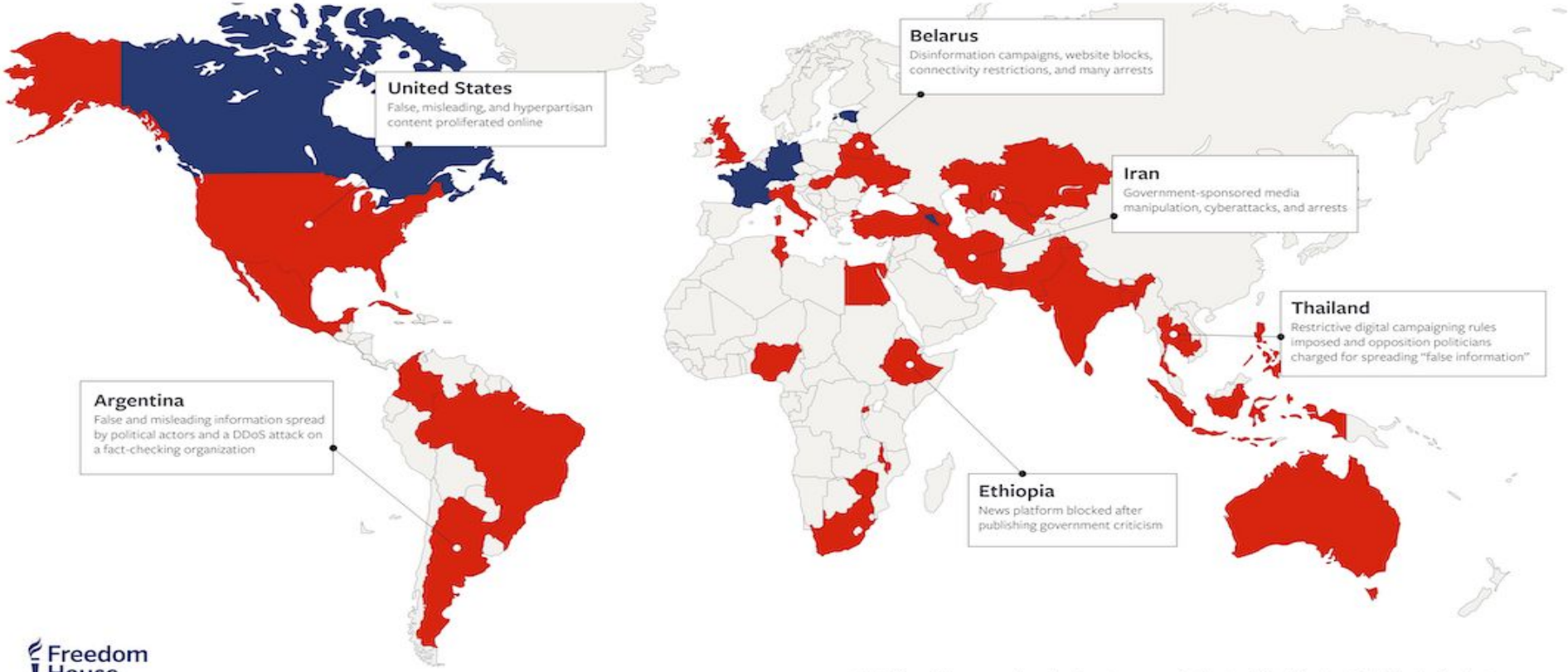
MAKE HACKING ATTEMPTS PUBLIC

Macron has been transparent all along about the hacking attempts, sensitizing people

Where Technology Has Disrupted Election Integrity

Domestic digital interference marred the online landscape in at least 88 percent of selected countries that held elections or referendums from June 2018 through May 2020.

With Digital Election Interference | **Without** Digital Election Interference | No Data



Freedom House

This infographic was produced in December 2020 for Election Watch for the Digital Age by freedomhouse.org.

US

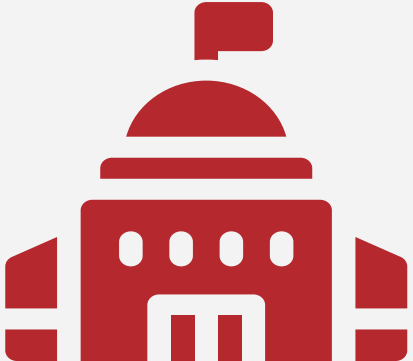
THE HISTORY OF “RIGGED” US ELECTIONS

American history is hardly lacking in <u>examples of real voter manipulation</u>

- Persistent problems with the **reliability** of its **voting machinery**
- Frequent **bureaucratic incompetence**
- **Systematic exclusion** and **lack of uniform standards**
- Tendency of election officials to **adopt rules for benefits over democracy**

Contested elections in American history at the presidential level involve serious allegations by top officials that the **election was "stolen."** Examples :

- ➔ *Aaron Burr - 1800 election*
- ➔ *William Taft - 1912 elections*
- ➔ *Bush v Gore - 2000 elections*
- ➔ *Trump false claims of fraud - 2020 elections*



DISINFORMATION IN 2020 ELECTIONS

COVID-19 → Presidential elections **heavily reliant on mail-in ballots**, impacted by the **spread of fake news rapidly increased.**

↓

Most of them was circulated from Republicans and President Donald Trump, shared via his personal social media account : Strategy to gain voters and consolidate support, leading to his win in 2016 vs Clinton.

RESULT : **Conspiracy theories** and **baseless claims** about **voter fraud** fueling an anti-democratic movement to overturn the election.

- **Dis**information vs **mis**information

FAKE

PROPAGANDA AND FAKE NEWS

Fake News Machine and Trend Micro increase concern about hacking elections

400,00$

To spend on fake news and propaganda

- Manipulating election outcomes can also be relatively **cheap** for politicians and parties, offering a **cost-effective alternative** to traditional promotion.

*"Fake news **fabricated as truth**, promising an **illusion of the future**, enough to compel people to **join an imagined cause**".*

Future
Next Exit

CONCLUSIONS : GLIMPSE OF THE FUTURE

EU POLICY → **Guidelines** under the **DSA** to **mitigate systemic risks**

- Election-related risks and specific guidance **on platforms**
- Generative AI content and **online risks** (ex. Deep fakes)

Safe way to engage, discuss and decide without illegal interference

+

SOCIAL MEDIA POLICIES VS FAKE NEWS :
PRECAUTIONARY WARNINGS

Effective at reducing the sharing of false news and increasing the share of true news

Key learnings

- ★ Agenda-setting uses issues to draw votes
- ★ Voters' manipulation implies voting strategies based on their perception on the electoral outcome
- ★ Communication media as tools used to influence voters' perception
- ★ How the question is stated and the option they can select can mislead voters
- ★ Alternative facts are highly persuasive, and fact-checking is not enough
- ★ Cyberattacks on politicians are frequent, but their effect can be mitigated
- ★ AI & fake news increasingly powerful: responsible resource consultation

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Thank you
for your attention

Any questions?

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